

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

Most patchwork and many appliqué quilts are based on patterns comprised of blocks – that is, squares made following the same pattern, which are then assembled to make the quilt top. This means that they can be broken down into working units that are

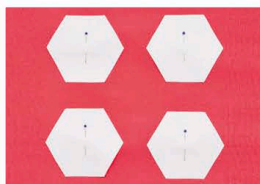
easier to cope with than a large overall design. There are hundreds of existing block designs that you can make in fabrics and colours of your own choice (see pp.54–57) but, once you understand the basic principles, it's fun to design patterns of your own.

▶▶ USING TEMPLATES

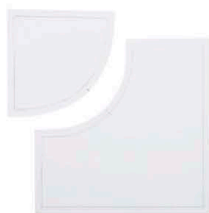
Some elements require templates, which are copies of the pieces of the pattern. Ready-made templates are available. Find out if the seam allowances have been added. Elements to be machine pieced must include the exact seam allowances, while appliqué patterns and those for hand piecing do not need a precise allowance, but are generally cut larger than the finished shape. Many templates are cut with a “window” that shows the area of fabric you will finish up with; this also enables you to mark the seamline and the cutting line without moving the template. Alternatively, you can make your own templates following these instructions.



Limited-use templates using freezer paper: Trace the pattern pieces onto freezer paper and cut them out. Iron the waxy side onto the wrong side of the fabric and then cut out around the shape.



Limited-use templates using tracing paper: Pin the template in place and cut out the shape, again adding the seam allowances by eye.



Durable templates using heavy card: Draw the shapes on paper or tracing paper. Cut them out, draw around them again on heavy card, and cut them out, or glue the shapes to the card and cut out.



Durable templates using template plastic: Trace the shapes directly onto the template plastic, or cut the desired shapes from paper and glue them to template plastic. Cut them out with paper scissors.

PLANNING YOUR OWN BLOCKS

The main patchwork block categories are four-patch (see p.54), nine-patch (see p.54), five-patch and seven-patch (see p.55). Each one lends itself to certain finished block sizes. Four-patch patterns can always be divided by even numbers, while nine-patch blocks are easiest to work with if the finished size is divisible by three. Five-patch and seven-patch patterns are more limited; they are multiples of 5 x 5 and 7 x 7 units (or patches) per block respectively.

If you want to design your own block pattern, start by deciding what size you want your finished block to be and draw it on paper, sub-dividing it into the relevant number of patches. Further sub-divide each patch into strips, triangles, smaller squares, or rectangles to create your design. When you are satisfied, transfer each element to another piece of paper and add a seam allowance to each side of each separate element.

With appliqué patterns, enlarge or reduce the pattern if necessary (see p.34) and copy it onto tracing paper. Decide which elements should be cut as separate pieces and trace them individually onto another piece of tracing paper so they can be cut out and used as patterns.

Many blocks can be super-sized by dramatically increasing the dimensions of a single block, making quilts of an ideal size for baby quilts. Combining several of these bigger blocks allows the quick creation of a full-size quilt.